

But money, as always, was an issue. The internship was unpaid. This confused me. I'd never encountered an unpaid job before. Ross Eisenbrey of the Economic Policy Institute said "glamorized" industries started offering unpaid internships because in an economic recession, where young people are desperate for work or for upwardly mobile positions, these industries realized they could now get "quality people for nothing." In 2014, *Forbes* reported that the National Association of Colleges and Employers found that from the mid-1980s to the mid-2000s, the number of college graduates participating in at least one internship rose from "less than 10 percent to over 80 percent." Just 37 percent of students who do an unpaid internship reported that it led to a job offer, only 2 percent higher than students who did no internships at all. Was it worth it?

I grappled with potentially turning down *The Daily Show* and instead staying in Boston for the summer working at my paid internship at the *Globe*. My parents were so disappointed I'd even consider telling Viacom no. They knew how much it would mean to me to work for *The Daily Show*, and the doors putting *TDS* on my résumé could potentially open. It was 2009, just after Barack Obama had been elected, and politics was cool again. All eyes were on *The Daily Show* now. Jon Stewart was a rock star. There was no *Full Frontal with Samantha Bee* yet. No indie political talk shows on YouTube. No satirical news podcasts. Stewart was THE GUY.

The internship was for college credit only, and while I could sublet my place in Boston for the summer, I'd need to find a similarly inexpensive apartment in New York City to funnel that rent money into. The real estate market in Manhattan and the one in the Allston neighborhood of Boston where I lived are not, it turns out, remotely comparable. I'd be bleeding money the entire summer. Still, I wanted to work for Comedy Central, a network I'd stayed up late watching all through high school.

There was also another problem: I was a journalism student, and Emerson didn't consider working for Comedy Central, even the network's political talk show, to be journalism. Since it wasn't an internship within my major, Emerson declined to give me college credit to do it. I couldn't do the internship for pay, and I couldn't do it for credit.